CORRIGÉ · PROBLÈME · ANNALES SPÉ

To what extent should ethical eating be encouraged ?

Énoncé

Même article (Beyond Meat, *The Financial Express*, 2023).

Sales at vegan burger maker Beyond Meat fall by almost a third

It launched with the promise to "eat what you love", but consumers' love affair with Beyond Meat's pricey meat substitutes is waning. Quarterly sales at the vegan burger maker have slumped by almost a third as shoppers shift away from expensive meat substitutes amid the cost of living crisis.

The US company, whose plant-based products include "burgers that appear to bleed" and imitations of sausages and meatballs, has cut its annual revenue forecast in the latest sign that the fake meat food bubble is bursting. After several years of rapid expansion fuelled by a splurge of private equity investment, meat substitutes have dropped off many menus. Sales unexpectedly slid 6% in the UK last year.

Vegan specialists including Meatless Farm of Leeds and Lincolnshire-based Plant & Bean, which supplied companies including Quorn and Tesco's Wicked Kitchen, called in administrators earlier this year as they battled lacklustre sales and hefty cost increases. Meanwhile, Sweden's Oatly, the Swiss food company Nestlé and the London-based Innocent Drinks, which is owned by Coca-Cola, are among those that have pulled vegan products from sale in the UK this year.

As the cost of living crisis has put pressure on household budgets, shoppers have turned to cheaper proteins including processed meat and traditional vegan or vegetarian options such as chickpeas, lentils and beans.

Alice Pilkington, a food analyst at Mintel, said people expected that cutting down on meat would save them money but the price of fake meat products was becoming "increasingly a barrier as they were on a par or more expensive than meat or more traditional alternatives".

Enthusiasm has also been dampened by concerns about the highly processed nature of some fake meats, highlighted by recent investigations into the health impacts of ultra-processed foods, as well as a shift towards cooking from scratch using basic ingredients during the Covid pandemic lockdowns.

Ethan Brown, the chief executive of Beyond Meat, said the ambiguity around the health benefits of eating plant-based meat had held back sales. "This change in perception is not without encouragement from interest groups who have succeeded in seeding doubt and fear around the ingredients and process used to create our and other plant-based meats," he said. The company is now forecasting that sales will fall by at least 9% this year to no more than $380m, down from previous hopes of up to $415m.

Adapted from The Financial Express, August 28, 2023

1. In your opinion, to what extent should ethical and sustainable eating be further encouraged ? (180 words, ± 10%)

Décoder l'énoncé

Ce que l'énoncé te donne.

- *To what extent* appelle une réponse nuancée : jusqu'où, par quels moyens, avec quelles limites.
- *Further* : on encourage déjà ; faut-il aller plus loin ?

Ce qu'on te demande. Un essai de 162 à 198 mots, argumenté et illustré.

Corrigé

Question 2

Étape 1. Analyser le sujet

- **To what extent** : on ne répond pas par oui ou non ; on fixe une limite (jusqu'où encourager) et des conditions (comment).
- **Ethical and sustainable eating** : manger moins de viande, mais aussi produits locaux, bien-être animal, gaspillage. Ne pas réduire le sujet aux steaks végétaux de l'article.
- **Further encouraged** : il existe déjà des incitations (étiquettes, cantines, taxes) ; la question est d'aller plus loin, et par qui (État, entreprises, écoles).

Problématique : faut-il seulement informer, ou orienter activement les choix alimentaires, au risque de culpabiliser les ménages modestes ?

Plan en trois temps (sans l'annoncer dans l'introduction) :
1) pourquoi encourager ;
2) les limites (coût, culture, liberté) ;
3) une position nuancée : rendre l'option durable plus facile plutôt que moraliser.

Sources de la méthode : rapports du jury du concours commun Mines-Ponts (épreuve écrite de langues, consignes reprises chaque année), en particulier le rapport sur les épreuves écrites. Le rapport propre à la session 2024 n'était pas accessible en ligne au moment de la rédaction : les remarques ci-dessous appliquent ces consignes générales au sujet 2024.

Étape 2. Essai modèle (183 mots)

Livestock farming accounts for roughly 14% of global greenhouse gas emissions, yet meat remains at the heart of most Western diets. The real question is therefore not whether our eating habits should change, but how far public authorities should go in steering them.

There is a strong case for encouraging more sustainable diets. Eating less red meat benefits both the planet and public health, and governments already shape our choices through taxes, labels and school canteens. In France, for instance, canteens have served a weekly vegetarian meal since 2019, without any real outcry.

However, encouragement must not turn into moral pressure. Food is bound up with culture, pleasure and income, and the Beyond Meat case shows that ethical products fail when they are expensive and heavily processed. Asking struggling households to pay more in order to feel virtuous is neither fair nor effective.

The most promising path is to make the sustainable option the easiest one : affordable pulses, honest labelling and support for farmers who change their methods. Ethical eating will spread when it is cheaper and tastier, not when it is preached.

183 words

Étape 3. Pourquoi cet essai répond aux attentes

- **Introduction** : un fait précis (la part de l'élevage dans les émissions, environ 14 % selon la FAO), puis la problématique reformulée. Pas d'annonce de plan.
- **Un paragraphe par idée**, chacun ouvert par une phrase qui annonce l'argument (*There is a strong case for…*, *However…*).
- **Exemples précis** : le menu végétarien hebdomadaire dans les cantines françaises (loi EGalim, 2019), et l'article lui-même utilisé comme un exemple parmi d'autres, pas comme seul argument.
- **Réponse à « to what extent »** : oui à l'encouragement, non à la culpabilisation, et un moyen concret (rendre l'option durable moins chère et plus simple).
- **Chute** courte et frappante, qui reprend la thèse sans la répéter mot pour mot.

Expressions utiles : *there is a strong case for*, *to be bound up with*, *to steer*, *neither… nor*, *the most promising path is to*, *to fall through*, *to make something the default option*.

Le piège

Une introduction de 50 mots de généralités (« Nowadays, food is very important… ») : il ne reste plus assez de mots pour argumenter.

La méthode

Essai en 180 mots : accroche précise et problématique (2 phrases), deux ou trois paragraphes d'un argument illustré chacun, une conclusion nuancée qui répond à la question telle qu'elle est posée.

Rappels de cours utilisés

- **Méthode : essai argumenté (180 mots).**
  - Introduction brève : une accroche concrète et la problématique, sans annoncer de plan.
  - Lire précisément les mots du sujet (ici *to what extent*, *ethical*, *sustainable*, *further*).
  - Un paragraphe par idée, chacune illustrée par un exemple précis.
  - Une réponse nuancée à « to what extent » : jusqu'où, et à quelles conditions.
  - Chaque mot compte : pas de généralités creuses, pas de reprise de l'article comme seul argument.